

Recommendation Letters Procedures

1 Information for Students and Staff

The department will send out recommendation letters in these ways:

1. **EJM** (<https://econjobmarket.org>)
2. **AcademicJobsOnline** (<https://academicjobsonline.org>)
3. **AEA** (<https://aeaweb.org>)
4. **Interfolio** (<https://www.interfolio.com>)
5. “Pull” Email (that is, when the employer, after receiving your application, sends an email to your recommenders asking them to upload the letters to a special-purpose site that the employer has set up)
6. “Push” Email (that is, when the employer provides an email address to which letters should be sent)

All of these methods require that your recommenders send PDFs of their letters to jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu. However, you should NOT ask them to send their letters until you have done the things that YOU are supposed to do (detailed below).

- A few employers (mostly industry) may ask that the PDFs be “digitally signed.”
- For now, we will ignore this demand.
- If such employers start to make up a critical mass, we will have to figure out how to train the faculty in how to make digitally signed letters.

Note that these options do NOT include a method of getting letters to any employer that has set up its own database system and wants recommenders and/or students to register for a username, password, etc. In practice, such places will invariably accept letters sent by email to some department staff person, and that is what we will do. YOU need to find out the email address of that staff person. If there are any employers that absolutely insist that applicants and recommenders learn to use their own unique systems, letters to those employers will be completed only AFTER ALL OTHER LETTERS FOR ALL OTHER STUDENTS have been sent using the preferred methods listed above. This is vitally important because from past experience we know that the confusion and delays caused by proprietary systems have the potential to end up making everyone’s letters late, so we can do this only once that risk has been eliminated. The only exception to this rule is the IMF, which has its own procedures that we do follow.

Some employers have a deadline before Nov 1 (a few as early as Oct 15), but the median employer has deadlines in middle to late November. Finally, employers with late job postings may appear in the December JOE.

This means that, in your **Employers[Moniker].xslsm** worksheet, you will need to mark each employer with an indicator for which ‘batch’ the letters should be assigned to:

Batch	Contains	You Finish By
Early	ALL due BEFORE Nov 15 AND HALF of Nov 15 deadlines	Oct 15
Middle	Remaining Nov 15 deadlines	Nov 1
Late	Post-Nov 15 deadlines	Nov 15
Late-Post	New listings as they trickle in Communicate with Luna	Ongoing after Nov 15

You will keep track of the employers that correspond to each batch by attaching the appropriate label to that employer in a special column in the spreadsheet. There should be at least a week between the date when you send the spreadsheet and the earliest application due-date contained therein. Finally any new job postings that trickle in after Nov 15 will be handled on a piecemeal basis as part of the “Late-Post” batch.

Broadly, for each iteration your steps are as follows:

1. Produce your version of **Employers[Moniker]** (by “your version” I mean, of course, to rename the template file to, for example, **EmployersThomK.xslsm** if you are Kevin Thom).
2. Sort your **Employers[Moniker]** spreadsheet according to five sort keys:
 - a) Date on which the staff are to send the recommendation letters;
 - b) Method of recommendation (**AEA**, **AcademicJobsOnline**, **EJM** , **Interfolio**, push email (for sorting purposes, label it “email-push”), pull email (label it “email-pull”), or “other” with the understanding that anything in “other” will be sent only after ALL other recommendations for ALL other students are sent);
 - c) Academic vs. Nonacademic;
 - d) Domestic vs. Foreign;
 - e) Employer Name.

(There is a macro (**Ctrl+w**) built into **Employers[Moniker]** that can be executed to accomplish this sort – see the instructions in **Employers[Moniker]**’s **Instructions** tab).

3. Then send an email message **Employers[Moniker]** to **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu** AND to **placement.jhuecon@gmail.com**, letting us know that your list is complete (for whatever is the “batch” you have been working on)

4. *After having sent their Employers[Moniker].xlsm spreadsheet*, the student should follow the steps outlined in detail below for those applications that involve either push or pull email. *item After taking care of their push and pull email applications*, students should complete their **EJM** , **AcademicJobsOnline**, **AEA**, and **Interfolio** applications for this round (see below for details).
5. *After having done all of this*, the student should email their recommenders and ask them to send their letters to **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**. Note that your request to recommenders needs to come last because if the letters arrive before the other steps have been taken, the employer probably won't have a file for you and the letters may get lost. (Though it would be wise to remind your advisors a week or two beforehand that letters from them will be needed soon).

Here are some requests from Luna:

1. Letter requests MUST to go to **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**
 - NOT to my personal @jhu.edu address
 2. DO NOT HIDE ROWS on the excel sheet
 - You may be doing this to make it easier for you to navigate
 - It makes it HARDER for me to determine what has been done
 - DO NOT DISABLE the macros - I use them extensively
 - ALWAYS use EXCLUSIVELY the version on OneDrive
 - Do NOT send me your spreadsheet as an email attachment
 3. Make sure each row is properly labeled, **as described above**
 - push, pull, EJM, JOE, AJO, etc
 4. Make sure the Job Title matches the job posting
 - Especially for jobs from the same employer
 - Otherwise an app to the business school might go to the Econ department
 - Particularly if you are applying to both
1. **EJM** (<https://econjobmarket.org>):
 - For JHU faculty recommenders, **EJM** identifies recommenders using an official JHU email addresses.
 - Many faculty already have an **EJM** account; for these recommenders, it will be obvious how to make **EJM** send the recommender a request for a letter.

- Some faculty members may not yet have an **EJM** account. For security reasons, **EJM** now insists that each recommender can have only one account at **EJM**, associated with a unique @jhu.edu email address. Even though the faculty member may never use that email address (instead, for example, using a gmail account for all correspondence), they nevertheless do *have* a JHU email address. If they don't know what it is, they can ask **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**. You need to find out from the faculty member what email address they want you to give to **EJM** when it asks for their address. Once you give **EJM** that email address, a message will be sent to the email address informing the faculty member that an account has been established in their name at **EJM**. After logging in, they should designate **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu** as a “proxy” or “surrogate” who can load their letters for them, and so when you request subsequent letters the request should actually go to **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**, who will receive a “pull” email notification and has to click on the link provided for each recommender, click on the name of the student who required the letter, upload the letter, and select all the employers.
 - Recommenders who are not Department of Economics full-time faculty and who do NOT have their own login ID at **EJM** will need to have an account created for them (the account is created automatically the first time a student identifies the recommender by giving **EJM** the recommender's email address), then they must upload their letters themselves.¹ New **EJM** security measures prevent us from uploading letters on behalf of people who are not JHU faculty, including recently departed JHU faculty who still have an official JHU email (the letter writer must write from their new institution). The student must communicate this information to the recommender.
2. **AcademicJobsOnline** (<https://academicjobsonline.org>): Students will enter Luna's name, with the email address **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**, on the cover sheet provided by the AJO system. Check the box: “must check here if the person above will upload letters on behalf of multiple writers” and enter the actual writers' names in the box provided. After all reference letters for each student are received, Luna will make 1 PDF file of all letters and upload their file to the AJO site. The student will be allowed to see when this upload is complete. This service will be provided for both JHU Economics and external recommenders.
 3. **AEA** (<https://aeaweb.org>): Students who are using **AEA** must ask their JHU Economics Department reference writer to go to <https://aeaweb.org> and set up a surrogate for their reference letters. The surrogate name is Luna Thomas and the email address is **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**. For details, see the **Information For Faculty** section.

¹They follow the same steps that the staff completes in the bullet point about JHU faculty. They log in, they upload their letter, they indicate that it's for, e.g., **colleen.carey@jhu.edu**, and then they select all employers and tick the box for all future employers.

4. **Interfolio** (<https://www.interfolio.com>): Before using the Interfolio System, students must wait for an email from Luna indicating that she has received *all* your letters of recommendation. Luna will tell you if you have multiple letters of recommendation from a specific faculty member as well as the type of recommendation (for example: Generic, Academic, or Non-Academic). *Do not proceed* with the recommendation requests if you don't know the type of recommendation letter you are getting from each specific faculty member.

When entering the recommendation requests in Interfolio please make sure to:

- Start the recommendation request by going to “Letters” in the left menu bar.
- Enter the recommender as Luna Thomas and `jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu` as the e-mail for each recommendation request. You need to do this as many times as the number of recommendation letters you are expecting to have.
- For each recommendation request, specify under “Document Title” the recommender’s actual name (e.g. Dr. Laurence Ball) and the type of the recommendation letter (generic, academic, non-academic. etc.) per Luna’s e-mail. For example, if Luna emailed you that Professor Ball wrote you both academic and non-academic letters of recommendation, one of your document titles would be: `Dr. Laurence Ball_non-academic recommendation` and another would be `Dr. Laurence Ball_academic recommendation`.
- “Description” – leave blank.
- “Message to Recommender” – leave as is.
- Under “Recommendation Type” there are two choices – General and Specific position. Only choose “Specific position” and enter the recommender actual name along with the type of the reference letter (generic, academic, non-academic). For example: `Dr. Laurence Ball_non-academic recommendation`.
- “Due date” - this is irrelevant, just choose a date a few days ahead. Your actual deadlines are already included in the spreadsheets sent to Luna.

All Interfolio reference letters will be uploaded to Interfolio directly by Luna, including the ones from external recommenders.

5. **Pull email:** Some employers have set up systems that allow recommenders to upload letters directly themselves. These employers will ask the student to provide the email address of each person who is to provide a letter. The employer then sends an email to each of those email addresses, requesting that the letter be uploaded. (This is a “pull” system because the employer is trying to “pull” the letter from the recommender.)

In order for us to keep track of letters in a centralized way, and to relieve recommenders of the burden of figuring out how to upload their letters, our procedure is as follows. When the employer asks for the email address of a JHU faculty

recommender, you should always reply with `jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu` rather than the faculty member's actual email.

If the recommender is not a JHU faculty member but they would like **JMStaff** to handle uploading their letters, you should just use `jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu` as the recommender's email address. If the recommender *wants* to handle their letters themselves, then you can give the employer their real email address. But this is discouraged, because it means that we do not have any way to track whether the letters have been sent or not.

6. **Push email:** Some employers just provide an email address to which letters should be sent. In order to speed up the process, students will provide the staff with as few as possible email groups (in general two, for academic and non-academic employers). For push email, we do not make any distinction between JHU faculty recommenders and outside recommenders; **JMStaff** will simultaneously send out letters of both kinds of recommenders using the procedure below. Students will send to `jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu` one single email with subject "email lists for recommendation letters for (your name)" whose content will look like this:

- **GROUP 1** (recommenders: Prof. Carroll, etc.)
 - **subject:** Academic Recommendation Letters Needed for (your name)
 - **Body:** employer1@aaa.aaa; employer2@aaa.aaa; employer3@aaa.aaa; etc.
- **GROUP 2** (recommenders: Jesus H. Christ, Carl Christ, Adrian Pagan, etc.)
 - **subject:** Nonacademic Recommendation Letters Needed for (your name)
 - **Body:** employer1@aaa.aaa; employer2@aaa.aaa; employer3@aaa.aaa; etc.
- **GROUP 3** (recommenders: James Bond, etc.)
 - **subject:** Extra super secret special jobs Recommendation Letters for (your name)
 - **Body:** employer1@aaa.aaa; employer2@aaa.aaa; employer3@aaa.aaa; ...

NOTE: *All email addresses included in the groups must be separated by a semicolon.*

The staff should create one email for each group (copying and pasting the "Subject" fields from the student's email) and attach the appropriate letters (academic or nonacademic). If error messages are returned (for example for a mistyped email address, or over quota of the recipient's account, etc.), the staff will forward the error message (but not the recommendation letter!) to the student in question. The student must determine the reason for the error and provide the staff with an alternative email address.

2 Information for Staff

Most of what the staff will do for recommendation letters is implicit in the previous section. To summarize:

- a) The **Employers[Moniker]** spreadsheet from a student should be accessible to you automatically. When you receive it, insert a new Column A and save the spreadsheet to the student's electronic folder located on the (X) drive or Stella as it is named. This new column will be used to mark off each employer once their letters are sent to them.
- b) *After* you receive that spreadsheet, you should start receiving requests for letters through **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**.
- c) Some naughty students may request letters via **EJM** or the push or pull email procedures before they have created their spreadsheet; if you receive such requests before having received the student's spreadsheet, please send them a message asking them to IMMEDIATELY construct their **Employers[Moniker]** spreadsheet (and put it in the right place).
- d) Whenever you fulfill a request for letters through **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**, keep track in the student's spreadsheet.
- e) If a deadline is looming and you do NOT have a checkmark on the student's spreadsheet, there may be a problem of some kind: The employer mistyped the email address for **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**, the student made a mistake somewhere, etc. As the big deadlines approach, please look at the spreadsheets and see whether there are letters that should have been sent but have not been.

3 Information for Faculty

The list of ways in which we are prepared to send letters is available [at this link](#).

You do not need to master all these. Instead, you will send a PDF of your letter to Luna, who will take care of the rest.

However, if you are not already registered with the various authorities, there are a few steps you will need to take, adumbrated below:

1. **AEA**: You likely already have an **AEA** account tied to your JHU email address.
2. If not, you will need one:
 - Go to <https://aeaweb.org>, login, and click "Settings" (or maybe "Preferences") to get to the place where you can register a surrogate, which should of course be **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**.
3. The job candidate will select you as a writer using the email address under which you are registered on <https://aeaweb.org>. When a candidate has selected you, the AEA will send you an email informing you of the fact. If you have already set Luna as your surrogate, you do not need to do anything (except send the letter to the surrogate when ready).

Let Luna autofulfill letters:

On both **EJM** and **AEA** there is an option to automatically fulfill letters whenever an employer requests them. Please do NOT do this – leave it to Luna.

- Luna is designated as the ‘single source of truth’
 - responsible for knowing which letters have been sent
- This is difficult if letters are being fulfilled in ways unknown to Luna
- Luna has acquired the expertise to navigate the various systems
 - It would be a substantial collective waste of faculty time to ask each faculty member to do this

4. **EJM:** Each JHU faculty member sending a recommendation letter will need to have an account at **EJM** (<https://econjobmarket.org>). Your account is first established by the STUDENT who first requests a letter from you. That student must provide to **EJM** a valid @jhu.edu email address for you. Personal email addresses like those from gmail or yahoo are now prohibited by **EJM** for security reasons.

If you are not yet registered on **EJM** and a student provides **EJM** with a valid JHU email address for you inside **EJM**, that will become your unique **EJM** email address.

WARNING: You probably have 4-8 valid email addresses: [yourname]@jhu.edu, [variant-with-a-number]@jh.edu, [your-name]@johnshopkins.edu,

You want to have ONE address known to **EJM** (otherwise, you may have to log in for each email address multiple times). Even if you have written EJM letters before, a student might try to register you under another address. If so, I STRONGLY advise you to push back and ask the student to use whatever is your already-registered EJM address. (You can check whether you are registered by going to **EJM** and trying to log in using your best-guess email address.)

Once you have been registered for **EJM** and received a confirmation email to your JHU account, you can designate a “proxy” to handle the actual work of uploading your letters. We (the Job Market Collective Front) insist that you do things this way, because that provides us (the Front) with a centralized way of keeping track of where the process is. To repeat, you must NOT upload your letters yourself; you MUST designate a proxy.

The proxy is Luna Thomas; the email address to use for the proxy is **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**. The good thing about using a proxy is that you (as a faculty member) need only to send your letters out once, to **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu**, and everything else is handled for you after that.

5. **AcademicJobsOnline:** Each JHU faculty member must register at <https://academicjobsonline.org> and enter Luna Thomas as their proxy, using the **jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu** email address. To do this, log in to your account and click on the ‘proxy’ link near the bottom. This only needs to be done once and

the proxy works for all applicants the faculty may have on the job market that year.

6. **AEA:** Each faculty member must register at <https://aeaweb.org>. After you create an account, you will have to designate Luna as a surrogate to manage your reference letters. The surrogate name is LunaThomas and the email address is jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu. The faculty need to set Luna Thomas as their proxy each year, as this system does not carry their proxies over from year to year.
7. **AcademicJobsOnline** and **Interfolio:** Each faculty member should email their reference letters to Luna at jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu. Please follow the file naming convention outlined below. This service will be provided for both JHU Economics and external recommenders.

N.B.: When you send your letters to jmstaff-jhuecon@jhu.edu, please use self-explanatory names, like `CarrollCD-For-WhiteMN-Academic.pdf`, or `CarrollCD-For-WhiteMN-NonAcademic.pdf`, or, if the same letter is to be sent both to academic and to nonacademic employers, `CarrollCD-For-WhiteMN-Generic.pdf`.